



Senior School & Sixth Form
Bodiam, East Sussex TN32 5UJ
01580 830396

Nursery & Prep School
St Leonards, East Sussex TN37 7PW
01424 751555

admissions@claremontschool.co.uk . claremontschool.co.uk

Dear Year 8 Parents,

I am writing to inform you of an important update to our school's laptop policy. As part of our ongoing commitment to ensuring a safe, focused, and effective learning environment both now and in the future, we have reviewed the requirements for laptops and how they are managed within the school. Following this review, we will be introducing a number of changes designed to better support students' learning and wellbeing.

Laptop Policy for all new students (year 9 entry) 2026

Year 9 students in 2026/2027 are required to purchase a new digital device **with digitiser support and an active stylus pen** that meets the school equipment requirements.

All laptops must be handed in to the IT department by 3rd July 2026 to guarantee they are ready for September.

The School will set up administrator control of the laptop, and install software including:

- Smoothwall Filter and Monitor
- Microsoft Intune
- Microsoft 365 A3
- SentinelOne antivirus and security
- Windows 11 Pro

The current BYOD (bring your own device) policy will be suspended for Year 9. Only school controlled laptops will be allowed to be used in classrooms in Year 9. Students who do not purchase a laptop, that is school controlled, may have access to a stock of school chromebooks in lessons, if they are available.

School controlled devices will be clearly marked with a 'Claremont Secure' Logo.

The policy will roll out for each new year 9 intake in 2027, and 2028, when all years up to year 11 will have devices adequately secured, and controlled by the school.
School administrator control is removed when a student leaves the school.

The IT team will provide software-related support where appropriate. All responsibilities for the device's care, maintenance, repairs, and any resulting costs remain with the student and parents.

An annual technology bundle software fee of approx £50 will be added to the school invoice.

Safeguarding

The primary reason for moving towards this model of device management, is to ensure the school is fulfilling its statutory responsibilities towards safeguarding our students, (Keeping Children Safe in Education, Part 2, Paragraph 140 Filtering and Monitoring) whilst they are online, under the care of the school. With the school assuming responsibility (administrator control) for the device management, we will be able to download safeguarding software onto the devices, Smoothwall, which is widely required as the gold standard of internet filtering and device monitoring.

Under the current BYOD policy, where control of the device sits with the individual user, we are unable to install monitoring software. This therefore relies on the school filter to block harmful content, and physical monitoring by staff.

Digital monitoring allows the school to monitor how individuals are interacting with websites allowed past the filter. This is crucial, for example, to protect students from harmful content embedded within reputable websites, including social media, chat bots, and AI generated content. Recently we have highlighted both to parents and staff the risks associated with young people's interactions with AI, forming emotional dependency, and seeking mental health support from chatbots. We cannot rely on the safeguards built into the websites themselves. Digital key stroke monitoring is designed to flag these risks. It works by categorising harms, for example bullying, over sharing, vulnerability, sexual content, and levels the severity, and issues notifications to the Safeguarding team. If it picks up a level five risk they will immediately phone the school, or designated emergency contacts if it is out of hours. This is the system that is currently used on all school owned and managed devices. We have experience of it working extremely effectively.

A key advantage of Smoothwall is that it is software downloaded onto the device, and therefore the protection is 24/7, rather than simply when accessing the school network.

Academic achievement

Equipping students with active stylus capability devices is about far more than simply giving them access to technology, it is about enhancing learning and raising academic achievement. Digital tools have been shown to strengthen understanding in key subjects such as science and mathematics by making complex ideas more interactive and engaging. When learning feels dynamic and enjoyable, pupils are more motivated to participate and retain information more effectively.

Beyond subject knowledge, using modern touchscreen and stylus-capable devices helps young people develop essential skills for the twenty-first century, including digital literacy and the ability to manage their own learning effectively. These skills not only support academic success but also prepare students to thrive in modern, technology-rich environments. With the confidence to navigate blended and online learning, pupils gain a valuable head start in adapting to future educational opportunities.

Teachers play a vital role in this process, using monitoring tools to guide and support productive device use in the classroom. This ensures that technology remains a powerful aid to focus, creativity and achievement.

Future proofing

There is a clear move towards digital assessment. Major exam boards like AQA and OCR have been piloting digital exams in schools, and the government has expressed interest in adopting digital solutions to modernise the process. These pilots suggest that a future where traditional GCSE exams are fully online, or at least have a digital option, is possible within the coming years. It is obviously important that our students are very familiar with learning and working digitally.

I understand there will be many questions regarding this new policy. We have tried to think of as many questions as possible in our FAQ section attached, but if you have a question not answered, please do not hesitate to contact me.

Also included in this communication is a guide to purchasing a suitable device. It gives you clear specifications for top, middle and low price range laptops and gives examples of the types of laptops you can purchase. These are a guide, the important point is that the laptop meets the specification requirements outlined on the first page.

We have endeavoured to state this policy well in advance of your son/daughter arriving at the Senior School as you may wish to take advantage of the Black Friday deals.

I look forward to seeing some of you on Thursday 20th November at 8.30am for a coffee and a tour of the Senior School.

Yours sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Lea Owen'. The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first letter 'L' being particularly large and stylized.

Lea Owen
Deputy Principal